UPSC Weekly Current Affairs

9 – 15 November 2026 · 20 top stories · 30 also important · Sources: PIB and The Hindu

Subject	Stories	Headline to know
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Top stories of the week

COP31: Can negotiators finally deliver results? | The Hindu explains

Wed 11 Nov · Governance & Social Justice, Environment & Ecology · GS2, GS3

• From catastrophic floods in Nepal to record-breaking heat, droughts and wildfires, the climate crisis is no longer a future threat.
• As world leaders gather in Antalya for COP31, the focus has shifted from promises to implementation.

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **Environment:** India's NDCs (45% cut in emission intensity of GDP from 2005 levels by 2030, 50% non-fossil power capacity, net zero by 2070) and the principle of CBDR-RC.
• **International relations:** India speaks for the Global South on climate finance and technology transfer; carbon border taxes like the EU's CBAM affect Indian exports.
• **Internal security:** Open border can be misused for trafficking, fake currency and movement of criminals; SSB guards it.
• **Economy:** Hydropower trade (India buys Nepali power), cross-border rail and petroleum pipelines.

Static connect: UNFCCC & Paris Agreement

• UNFCCC adopted at the 1992 Rio Earth Summit; the Conference of Parties (COP) meets yearly.
• Paris Agreement (COP21, 2015): keep warming well below 2°C, pursue 1.5°C; countries submit NDCs.
• India's targets include net zero by 2070.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: COP31, Can, Hindu, From, Nepal

Source: The Hindu, Environment, 10 Nov 2026 ·
https://www.thehindu.com/videos/cop31-can-negotiators-finally-deliver-results-the-hindu-ex

Trump says likely to meet Putin, Xi at China APEC summit

Tue 10 Nov · International Relations · GS2

• President Donald Trump indicated to reporters that a deal on the Russia-Ukraine war, the Iran issue and nuclear arms control would be on the agenda

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **Internal security:** Unsettled LAC (eastern Ladakh, Arunachal): border infrastructure, disengagement and buffer zones; China's dual-use villages (Xiaokang) and dams on the Brahmaputra (Yarlung Tsangpo).
• **Economy:** Large trade deficit and dependence on Chinese inputs (APIs, electronics, solar, rare earths) drive PLI schemes, Press Note 3 (2020) FDI curbs and supply-chain diversification.
• **International relations:** Strategic competition in the Indian Ocean (String of Pearls), BRI vs connectivity alternatives (IMEC), and balancing via Quad while engaging in BRICS/SCO.

Static connect: APEC

• Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation, formed in 1989; 21 member economies around the Pacific Rim.
• India is not a member.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: Trump, Putin, China APEC, President Donald Trump, Russia-Ukraine

Source: The Hindu, International, 09 Nov 2026 · https://www.thehindu.com/news/international/us-china-russia-leaders-to-meet-next-week-says

Karnataka to write to Prime Minister asking for inclusion of enhanced quota in Ninth Schedule

Fri 13 Nov · Polity & Constitution, Governance & Social Justice · GS2

• After the High Court of Karnataka quashed the Karnataka Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Reservation of Seats in Educational Institutions and of Appointments or Posts in the Services under the State) Act, 2022, the State government will write to Prime Minister Narendra Modi to include the enhanced reservation for SCs and STs in the 9th Schedule of the Constitution

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **Governance & polity:** Judicial review and the separation of powers; such rulings often clarify fundamental rights or federal relations and become Mains examples.
• **Society:** Access to justice and pendency (over 5 crore cases) affect citizens' trust in institutions.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: Karnataka, Prime Minister, Ninth Schedule, After the High Court of Karnataka, Karnataka Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes

Source: The Hindu, National, 12 Nov 2026 · https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/karnataka/karnataka-to-write-to-prime-minister-aski

Island fisheries at the centre of India’s Blue Economy push

Tue 10 Nov · Agriculture · GS3

• India is endowed with a vast and diverse marine resource base, supported by a coastline of approximately 11,099 km and an Exclusive Economic Zone of nearly 24 lakh sq.
• With an estimated marine fisheries potential of 58.6 lakh MT within its EEZ, the sector plays a vital role in sustaining the livelihoods of nearly 50 lakh fishers, while contributing significantly to food security, nutrition, employment, income…

Static connect: Blue Economy

• India's coastline is about 11,099 km (revised measurement) and its Exclusive Economic Zone about 2 million sq km.
• Schemes include PM Matsya Sampada Yojana and the Deep Ocean Mission.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: Island, Blue Economy, Exclusive Economic Zone, EEZ

Source: PIB, Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry & Dairying, 10 Nov 2026 · https://pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2334511

COP31: Himalayan flash floods should push all to act ‘faster and fairer’ on climate change: UN climate chief

Fri 13 Nov · Environment & Ecology, International Relations · GS2, GS3

• “The glacial collapse and flash floods in the Himalayas this year are a devastating reminder of how fragile these mountain environments can be, particularly the Hindu Kush Himalayas,” UNFCCC Executive Secretary Simon Stiell said

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **Environment:** India's NDCs (45% cut in emission intensity of GDP from 2005 levels by 2030, 50% non-fossil power capacity, net zero by 2070) and the principle of CBDR-RC.
• **International relations:** India speaks for the Global South on climate finance and technology transfer; carbon border taxes like the EU's CBAM affect Indian exports.
• **Geography & disasters:** India is exposed to cyclones, floods and heatwaves; the Disaster Management Act, 2005 (amended 2025), NDMA and NDRF/SDRF lead the response.
• **Governance & polity:** Shift from relief to risk reduction (Sendai Framework); early warning, CDRI and climate-resilient infrastructure.

Static connect: UNFCCC & Paris Agreement

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• Paris Agreement (COP21, 2015): keep warming well below 2°C, pursue 1.5°C; countries submit NDCs.
• India's targets include net zero by 2070.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: COP31, Himalayan, Himalayas, Hindu Kush Himalayas, UNFCCC Executive Secretary Simon Stiell

Source: The Hindu, International, 13 Nov 2026 ·
https://www.thehindu.com/news/international/cop31-himalayan-flash-floods-should-push-all-t

Turkiye's President calls genocide in Gaza ‘ecocide’ at UN climate summit

Fri 13 Nov · International Relations · GS2

• “Centuries old olive trees have been cut down.
• The soil and water have been polluted in Gaza, and cities in Gaza have been turned into enormous piles of rubble,” the Turkish President said

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **Economy:** India imports most of its crude oil, much of it from the Gulf; conflict raises oil prices, shipping and insurance costs, inflation and the current account deficit.
• **Society:** About 9 million Indians live in the Gulf; their safety (evacuation operations such as Ajay/Kaveri) and remittances (India is the world's largest recipient) are at stake.
• **International relations:** India balances ties with Israel, Iran and the Arab states; projects like Chabahar and IMEC depend on regional stability.
• **Environment:** India's NDCs (45% cut in emission intensity of GDP from 2005 levels by 2030, 50% non-fossil power capacity, net zero by 2070) and the principle of CBDR-RC.

Static connect: Gaza Strip

• Narrow Palestinian territory on the Mediterranean coast, bordering Israel and Egypt (Rafah crossing).
• India's long-standing position supports a two-state solution.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: Turkiye, President, Gaza, Centuries, Turkish President

Source: The Hindu, International, 13 Nov 2026 ·
https://www.thehindu.com/news/international/turkiyes-president-calls-genocide-in-gaza-ecoc

India’s Renewable Energy Journey: Powering a Cleaner Future

Fri 13 Nov · Environment & Ecology, Economy · GS3

• India’s renewable energy landscape is expanding rapidly to meet rising demand, strengthen energy security, and support a cleaner future.
• The transformation spans solar, wind, hydro, bio-energy, geothermal and green hydrogen.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: Renewable Energy Journey, Powering, Cleaner Future, Policy, From

Source: PIB, PIB Backgrounder, 13 Nov 2026 · https://pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2335742

India reaffirms Commitment to Climate Multilateralism and a Fair, Ambitious Outcome at UNFCCC COP31, in Antalya (Türkiye)

Tue 10 Nov · Environment & Ecology · GS3

• India has reaffirmed its commitment to climate multilateralism and the principles of Equity and Common But Differentiated Responsibilities and Respective Capabilities (CBDR-RC), calling for a fair, equitable and ambitious outcome at the 31st Conference of the Parties (COP31) to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), being held in Antalya, Türkiye.
• Delivering India's Opening Statement at…

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **Environment:** India's NDCs (45% cut in emission intensity of GDP from 2005 levels by 2030, 50% non-fossil power capacity, net zero by 2070) and the principle of CBDR-RC.
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• India's targets include net zero by 2070.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: Commitment, Climate Multilateralism, Fair, Ambitious Outcome, UNFCCC COP31

Source: PIB, Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, 10 Nov 2026 ·
https://pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2334571

ED attaches properties in Kashmir in ‘misuse’ of PM Employment Generation Programme scheme case

Tue 10 Nov · Governance & Social Justice, Economy · GS2, GS3

• An ED spokesman said there was misappropriation of PMEGP Scheme’s loans in criminal conspiracy with the PMEGP borrowers, bank officials of Sumbal Branch and Gamud Gadkhud Branch of J&K Bank and other unknown persons

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **Internal security:** Infiltration, hybrid terrorists and narco-terror links; normalcy indicators such as tourism and voter turnout.
• **Governance & polity:** After the abrogation of Article 370 (2019, upheld by the Supreme Court in 2023), questions of statehood restoration and Sixth Schedule demands in Ladakh.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: Kashmir, PM Employment Generation Programme, PMEGP Scheme, PMEGP, Sumbal Branch and Gamud Gadkhud Branch

Source: The Hindu, National, 09 Nov 2026 ·
https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/jammu-and-kashmir/ed-attaches-properties-in-kashmir

Cyber bullying affects one in ten students worldwide; AI fuels new threat: UNESCO

Tue 10 Nov · International Relations, Science & Technology · GS1, GS2, GS3

• The United Nations agency has called upon countries to invest in digital safety measures, teacher preparation, and mental health support for students, in coordination with technology companies

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **Internal security:** Cyber attacks on critical infrastructure and fraud like 'digital arrest' scams; CERT-In, NCIIPC and I4C are the response agencies.
• **Governance & polity:** IT Act 2000, Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023, and the need for cyber hygiene and capacity in state police.
• **Science & tech:** IndiaAI Mission (2024) for compute, datasets and indigenous models; India hosted the AI Impact Summit in 2026.
• **Ethics:** Deepfakes, bias, privacy and accountability call for responsible-AI rules and platform obligations under the IT Rules.

Static connect: UNESCO lists

• World Heritage under the 1972 Convention; Intangible Cultural Heritage under the 2003 Convention.
• UNESCO also runs the Man and the Biosphere (MAB) programme and Global Geoparks.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: Cyber, UNESCO, United Nations

Source: The Hindu, Health, 09 Nov 2026 · https://www.thehindu.com/sci-tech/health/cyber-bullying-affects-one-in-ten-students-worldw

Supreme Court terms vehicular emissions major contributor to air pollution in Delhi-NCR

Tue 10 Nov · Governance & Social Justice, Environment & Ecology · GS2, GS3

• The Bench highlighted the large number of vehicles plying on roads connecting Delhi with neighbouring areas, including Ghaziabad, Greater Noida, Gurugram and Faridabad

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **Governance & polity:** Judicial review and the separation of powers; such rulings often clarify fundamental rights or federal relations and become Mains examples.
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• **Environment:** India's NDCs (45% cut in emission intensity of GDP from 2005 levels by 2030, 50% non-fossil power capacity, net zero by 2070) and the principle of CBDR-RC.
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Static connect: Air quality governance

• Commission for Air Quality Management in NCR (statutory since 2021) enforces the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP).
• National Clean Air Programme (NCAP, 2019) targets particulate reduction in non-attainment cities.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: Supreme Court, Delhi-NCR, Bench, Delhi, Ghaziabad

Source: The Hindu, Health, 09 Nov 2026 · https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/supreme-court-terms-vehicular-emissions-major-contr

G7 Foreign Ministers say China's actions east of Taiwan threaten stability

Thu 12 Nov · International Relations · GS2

• The G7 statement said the Ministers ■stressed the importance of maintaining peace and stability across the Taiwan Strait

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **Internal security:** Unsettled LAC (eastern Ladakh, Arunachal): border infrastructure, disengagement and buffer zones; China's dual-use villages (Xiaokang) and dams on the Brahmaputra (Yarlung Tsangpo).
• **Economy:** Large trade deficit and dependence on Chinese inputs (APIs, electronics, solar, rare earths) drive PLI schemes, Press Note 3 (2020) FDI curbs and supply-chain diversification.
• **International relations:** Strategic competition in the Indian Ocean (String of Pearls), BRI vs connectivity alternatives (IMEC), and balancing via Quad while engaging in BRICS/SCO.

Static connect: Taiwan Strait

• Separates Taiwan from mainland China and links the East and South China Seas.

Static connect: G7

• US, UK, France, Germany, Italy, Japan and Canada, with the EU taking part; India is often invited as an outreach partner.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: G7 Foreign Ministers, China, Taiwan, Ministers, Taiwan Strait

Source: The Hindu, International, 12 Nov 2026 ·
https://www.thehindu.com/news/international/g7-foreign-ministers-say-chinas-actions-east-o

Modi to visit Manila for ASEAN Summit; maritime security, trade on agenda

Fri 13 Nov · International Relations · GS2

• Modi is also set to join Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese, U.S.
• President Donald Trump, and Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi for the annual Quad summit in Manila.

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **International relations:** India's Act East Policy and vision of a free, open, rules-based Indo-Pacific (UNCLOS 1982); Quad and ASEAN centrality.
• **Economy:** A large share of India's trade passes through the Malacca Strait and South China Sea; disruption hits supply chains (semiconductors from Taiwan).
• **Internal security:** Protecting sea lanes, coastal security after 26/11, anti-piracy patrols in the Arabian Sea and Gulf of Aden; India as net security provider in the IOR.

Static connect: Quad

• India, the United States, Japan and Australia; focus on a free and open Indo-Pacific.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: Modi, Manila for ASEAN Summit, Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese, President Donald Trump, Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi

Source: The Hindu, International, 12 Nov 2026 ·
https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/modi-to-visit-manila-for-asean-summit-maritime-secu

UN nuclear watchdog urges Iran to take 'steps' towards inspections

Sat 14 Nov · International Relations, Science & Technology · GS2, GS3

• The International Atomic Energy Agency has not had access to key nuclear facilities in Iran since Israel and the U.S.
• launched a 12-day conflict in June 2025 that included strikes on nuclear sites

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **Economy:** India imports most of its crude oil, much of it from the Gulf; conflict raises oil prices, shipping and insurance costs, inflation and the current account deficit.
• **Society:** About 9 million Indians live in the Gulf; their safety (evacuation operations such as Ajay/Kaveri) and remittances (India is the world's largest recipient) are at stake.
• **International relations:** India balances ties with Israel, Iran and the Arab states; projects like Chabahar and IMEC depend on regional stability.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: Iran, International Atomic Energy Agency, Israel, June

Source: The Hindu, International, 13 Nov 2026 ·
https://www.thehindu.com/news/international/un-nuclear-watchdog-urges-iran-to-take-steps-t

Poland arrests two Ukrainians over alleged Russian espionage, sabotage

Wed 11 Nov · International Relations · GS2

• Poland has long ■accused Russia and its ally Belarus of waging a hybrid campaign involving sabotage, cyberattacks ■and disinformation since Moscow’s 2022 invasion of Ukraine

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **International relations:** India's strategic autonomy: abstentions at the UN, call for dialogue and diplomacy, while keeping ties with Russia and the West.
• **Economy:** Discounted Russian crude, fertiliser and defence spares; Western sanctions and secondary tariffs create payment and trade risks for India.
• **Internal security:** Dependence on Russian defence equipment (S-400, Su-30) and the push for indigenisation (Atmanirbhar Bharat in defence).
• **Governance & polity:** IT Act 2000, Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023, and the need for cyber hygiene and capacity in state police.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: Poland, Ukrainians, Russian, Russia, Belarus

Source: The Hindu, International, 10 Nov 2026 ·
https://www.thehindu.com/news/international/poland-arrests-two-ukrainians-over-alleged-rus

Now agentic AI can perform complex lab research, and maybe cheaper too

Fri 13 Nov · Science & Technology · GS3

• On November 4, 2026, in the journal Nature, researchers from Shanghai Jiao Tong University presented their findings on an Agentic laboratory platform, “AutoDNA”.
• It is an artificial intelligence system with agents performing the function of humans who usually perform complex experiments

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **Science & tech:** IndiaAI Mission (2024) for compute, datasets and indigenous models; India hosted the AI Impact Summit in 2026.
• **Ethics:** Deepfakes, bias, privacy and accountability call for responsible-AI rules and platform obligations under the IT Rules.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: November, Nature, Shanghai Jiao Tong University, Agentic, AutoDNA

Source: The Hindu, Science, 12 Nov 2026 ·
https://www.thehindu.com/education/now-agentic-ai-can-perform-complex-lab-research-and-may

Naturopathy Day 2026: Scientific Research Strengthens Indias Nature-Based Healthcare Ecosystem

Thu 12 Nov · Governance & Social Justice, Science & Technology · GS2, GS3

• Naturopathy in India is gradually moving beyond its traditional association with nature cure towards a more structured ecosystem of scientific research, clinical evaluation and preventive healthcare.
• With growing attention to lifestyle-related disorders, obesity, stress and healthy ageing, its emphasis on nutrition, natural therapies and lifestyle modification is finding renewed relevance.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: Naturopathy Day, Scientific Research Strengthens Indias Nature-Based Healthcare Ecosystem, Naturopathy, National

Source: PIB, AYUSH, 12 Nov 2026 · https://pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2335313

One Nation, One Ration Card

Thu 12 Nov · Agriculture, Governance & Social Justice · GS2, GS3

• The One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC) scheme was launched in 2019 by the Department of Food & Public Distribution.
• It is a major reform of the Public Distribution System (PDS) , enabling nationwide portability of ration cards and beneficiaries covered under the National Food Security Act (NFSA).

Prelims pointers

• NFSA establishes legal entitlements for subsidized food grains, while TPDS distributes these grains to eligible…
• Key terms: One Nation, One Ration Card, One Nation One Ration Card, ONORC, Department of Food

Source: PIB, PIB Backgrounder, 12 Nov 2026 · https://pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2335306

UN climate summit pushes electrification goal as groups call for mining safeguards

Fri 13 Nov · Environment & Ecology, International Relations · GS2, GS3

• The pledge builds on commitments made at previous UN climate summits: At COP28, countries agreed to work toward tripling renewable energy capacity and transitioning away from fossil fuels.
• COP29 focused on energy storage, grid modernisation and climate finance

Why it matters for India and UPSC

• **Environment:** India's NDCs (45% cut in emission intensity of GDP from 2005 levels by 2030, 50% non-fossil power capacity, net zero by 2070) and the principle of CBDR-RC.
• **International relations:** India speaks for the Global South on climate finance and technology transfer; carbon border taxes like the EU's CBAM affect Indian exports.

Static connect: UNFCCC & Paris Agreement

• UNFCCC adopted at the 1992 Rio Earth Summit; the Conference of Parties (COP) meets yearly.
• Paris Agreement (COP21, 2015): keep warming well below 2°C, pursue 1.5°C; countries submit NDCs.
• India's targets include net zero by 2070.

Prelims pointers

• Key terms: At COP28, COP29

Source: The Hindu, International, 13 Nov 2026 ·
https://www.thehindu.com/sci-tech/energy-and-environment/un-climate-summit-pushes-electrif

Govt. prohibits export of unsorted lithium-ion battery waste, scrap

Wed 11 Nov · Geography, Polity & Constitution · GS1, GS2, GS3

• The Government of India has prohibited the export of unsorted lithium-ion battery waste and scrap.
• Earlier classified under the 'Free' category, the move aims to retain critical battery material within the country for recycling.

Why it matters for India and UPSC

Securing lithium and other critical minerals is central to India's electric mobility and energy storage targets amid heavy reliance on imports.
• **Economy:** Incentivizes indigenous recycling capacities and protects supply chains from global supply shocks.
• **Environment:** Fosters a circular economy by diverting toxic e-waste into secondary raw material extraction.
• **International relations:** Reduces external vulnerabilities to foreign monopolies controlling the processing and refining of battery raw materials.

Static connect: Critical Minerals Policy in India

• The Ministry of Mines identified 30 critical minerals essential for economic development and national security.
• Battery Waste Management Rules, 2022 mandate Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) targets for recovery and recycling of battery materials.

Prelims pointers

• Export policy notifications for commodities are issued by the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) under the Ministry of Commerce and Industry.
• Lithium is designated as a critical and strategic mineral under the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2023.

Mains angle

Discuss the significance of retaining critical mineral waste in bolstering India's domestic battery recycling ecosystem and energy transition (GS Paper III - Economic Development & Industrial Policy).

Practice question

Examine the strategic and ecological necessity of developing a domestic circular economy for critical minerals. In this context, assess the impact of recent restrictions on the export of battery scrap.

Source: The Hindu, National, 11 Nov 2026 · https://www.thehindu.com/business/govt-prohibits-export-of-unsorted-lithium-ion-batterywas

Also important this week

AGRICULTURE

• **Cyclone Murasu damages over 274 hectares of crop area in Prakasam district** (The Hindu, National, 11 Nov 2026)
District Agriculture Officer says maize suffered the maximum damage across 154.17 hectares, followed by paddy and cotton crops sown on 66.02 hectares and 49.78 hectares respectively; APCPDCL restores power across 613 cyclone-affected villages in the district

Why it matters **Geography & disasters**: India is exposed to cyclones, floods and heatwaves; the Disaster Management Act, 2005 (amended 2025), NDMA and NDRF/SDRF lead the response.; **Governance & polity**: Shift from relief to risk reduction (Sendai Framework); early warning, CDRI and climate-resilient infrastructure.

• **CPI(M) seeks withdrawal of proposed Water Regulatory Commission** (The Hindu, National, 12 Nov 2026)
Party alleges it will privatise drinking and irrigation water, impose an additional financial burden on people and adversely affect agriculture

Why it matters **Economy**: RBI's MPC targets 4% CPI inflation (±2%); rate decisions affect EMIs, credit growth, investment and the rupee.; **Society**: Food inflation hits poor households the most; links to supply-side measures like buffer stocks and export curbs.

ECONOMY

• **Drone industry needs deeper localisation as import dependence poses risks: DFI** (The Hindu, National, 11 Nov 2026)
The dependence on foreign-made motors, batteries, flight controllers, communication systems and rare earth magnets leaves the sector vulnerable to supply disruptions and export restrictions, cautions Smit Shah, president, Drone Federation India

Why it matters **Internal security**: Narco-terror links across the Punjab border (Golden Crescent) and in the North-East (Golden Triangle); drones are used to drop drugs and arms.; **Society**: Drug abuse among youth; NDPS Act, 1985 and Nasha Mukt Bharat Abhiyaan.

• **India's exports up 29.9% in October; trade deficit narrows to $20.09 billion** (The Hindu, Economy, 13 Nov 2026)
The growth in India’s merchandise exports in October, the fastest in five years and faster than import growth, indicates that volumes of exports are growing along with prices

Why it matters **Economy**: Affects India's export competitiveness, MSMEs and jobs in labour-intensive sectors; India's recent FTAs include UAE, Australia, EFTA (TEPA) and the UK.; **International relations**: Trade is now a tool of geopolitics; India defends policy space at the WTO on food security (public stockholding) and agriculture.

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

• **Heat-trapping carbon pollution drops, but scientists cite Iran war rather than energy progress** (The Hindu, International, 10 Nov 2026)
In 2026, the world emitted 42.2 billion tonne of heat-trapping carbon dioxide from the burning of fossil fuels such as coal, oil and gas.

Why it matters **Economy**: India imports most of its crude oil, much of it from the Gulf; conflict raises oil prices, shipping and insurance costs, inflation and the current account defic; **Society**: About 9 million Indians live in the Gulf; their safety (evacuation operations such as Ajay/Kaveri) and remittances (India is the world's largest recipient) are

• **A case for Nepal: suing major carbon emitters for floods** (The Hindu, Environment, 09 Nov 2026)
While climate wrongs harm society, they do not harm individuals in a sufficiently direct and proximate way

Why it matters **International relations**: Open border under the 1950 Treaty of Peace and Friendship; map dispute over Kalapani–Lipulekh–Limpiyadhura; competition with Chinese investment.; **Internal security**: Open border can be misused for trafficking, fake currency and movement of criminals; SSB guards it.

• **Supreme Court goes beyond Deepavali AQI, flags vehicular emissions polluting Delhi air** (The Hindu, Environment, 10 Nov 2026)
The court says Delhi and the NCR bear the ‘cumulative burden of vehicular traffic’ and seeks to know what has been done to regulate in the capital the entry and plying of vehicles from neighbouring States

Why it matters **Governance & polity**: Judicial review and the separation of powers; such rulings often clarify fundamental rights or federal relations and become Mains examples.; **Society**: Access to justice and pendency (over 5 crore cases) affect citizens' trust in institutions.

• **Delhi's air quality improves to 'poor' due to increased wind speed** (The Hindu, Health, 10 Nov 2026)
On Monday, the day after Diwali, the capital's average Air Quality Index (AQI) stood at 376, in the 'very poor' category.

Why it matters **Environment**: Air pollution is a public-health emergency in North India; NCAP, GRAP and the Commission for Air Quality Management (2021) are the policy tools.; **Governance & polity**: Needs inter-state coordination (Punjab, Haryana, Delhi) and alternatives to stubble burning such as Happy Seeder and bio-decomposers.

• **Venezuela tells COP31 it has sovereign right to pump more oil** (The Hindu, International, 12 Nov 2026)
Venezuela’s Acting President ■Delcy Rodriguez’s comments at the UN ■talks on Turkiye’s Mediterranean coast jar with efforts by other conference leaders to convince global governments to accelerate a ■shift from carbon-emitting fossil fuels

Why it matters **Environment**: India's NDCs (45% cut in emission intensity of GDP from 2005 levels by 2030, 50% non-fossil power capacity, net zero by 2070) and the principle of CBDR-RC.; **International relations**: India speaks for the Global South on climate finance and technology transfer; carbon border taxes like the EU's CBAM affect Indian exports.

• **Urgent climate finance pleas at COP31 face a non-urgent response** (The Hindu, International, 13 Nov 2026)
Climate action has slipped down the political agenda for Western governments as U.S.

Why it matters **Environment**: India's NDCs (45% cut in emission intensity of GDP from 2005 levels by 2030, 50% non-fossil power capacity, net zero by 2070) and the principle of CBDR-RC.; **International relations**: India speaks for the Global South on climate finance and technology transfer; carbon border taxes like the EU's CBAM affect Indian exports.

• **Aaditya Thackeray calls for Climate Change Councils at Centre, State levels to tackle pollution** (The Hindu, Environment, 13 Nov 2026)
At the State level, he proposed similar councils chaired by the respective Chief Ministers, with participation from relevant departments to monitor the implementation of climate action plans

Why it matters **Environment**: India's NDCs (45% cut in emission intensity of GDP from 2005 levels by 2030, 50% non-fossil power capacity, net zero by 2070) and the principle of CBDR-RC.; **International relations**: India speaks for the Global South on climate finance and technology transfer; carbon border taxes like the EU's CBAM affect Indian exports.

GEOGRAPHY

• **Trump to meet Iran war mediator Qatar, no imminent deal seen to end war** (The Hindu, International, 09 Nov 2026)
Mutual attacks continue, with the U.S.

Why it matters **Economy**: US is India's largest export market; tariffs, H-1B visa rules and trade-deal talks hit IT services, textiles, gems and pharma exports and the rupee.; **International relations**: Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership: defence deals, iCET/TRUST technology cooperation, Quad; India balances this with strategic autonomy (Russian oil, BR

• **What are the findings of the 2024 Hindu Kush Himalayas snow update? | Explained** (The Hindu, Environment, 13 Nov 2026)
What does the report by the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development highlight?

Why it matters **Economy**: RBI's MPC targets 4% CPI inflation (±2%); rate decisions affect EMIs, credit growth, investment and the rupee.; **Society**: Food inflation hits poor households the most; links to supply-side measures like buffer stocks and export curbs.

GOVERNANCE & SOCIAL JUSTICE

• **NMC cautions students against fake medical colleges, asks them to verify approvals** (The Hindu, National, 10 Nov 2026)
The advisory follows the Supreme Court taking cognisance of the issue in an ongoing case in which the court directed regulatory bodies, including the National Medical Commission, to caution students and parents against dealing with unauthorised educational ins

Why it matters **Governance & polity**: Judicial review and the separation of powers; such rulings often clarify fundamental rights or federal relations and become Mains examples.; **Society**: Access to justice and pendency (over 5 crore cases) affect citizens' trust in institutions.

• **Deepavali pollution spike: How does it affect lung function and respiratory health? | Explained** (The Hindu, Health, 09 Nov 2026)
Firecracker smoke releases fine particles and harmful gases that irritate the airways and affect lung health.

Why it matters **Environment**: Air pollution is a public-health emergency in North India; NCAP, GRAP and the Commission for Air Quality Management (2021) are the policy tools.; **Governance & polity**: Needs inter-state coordination (Punjab, Haryana, Delhi) and alternatives to stubble burning such as Happy Seeder and bio-decomposers.

• **India’s efforts to clean its air need not slow its economic growth** (The Hindu, Science, 11 Nov 2026)
Highlights the need to decouple air pollution mitigation from economic slowdown through targeted developmental interventions.

Why it matters **Environment**: Emphasizes targeted sectoral interventions over blunt industrial bans to lower PM2.5 and PM10 levels.; **Economy**: Promoting clean cooking and industrial efficiency avoids productivity losses linked to poor health and fossil-fuel dependence.

• **Keralam to launch Family Sustainability Mapping to identify children in high-risk environments** (The Hindu, National, 12 Nov 2026)
Minister for Women and Child Development Bindhu Krishna says circumstances of families and children will be assessed with cooperation of schools, Anganwadis, local self-government institutions, District Child Protection Units, healthcare workers and police

Why it matters **Society**: Women's safety, workforce participation and representation (Women's Reservation Act 2023, one-third seats after delimitation).; **Governance & polity**: Laws such as the POSH Act 2013 and the new criminal laws (BNS 2023) and their implementation gaps.

• **Eisenkot urges respect for Israel's Arab minority after Netanyahu attacks** (The Hindu, International, 13 Nov 2026)
Two Arab-majority parties, Raam and the Joint List, secured a combined 19 seats in last month's election, winning nearly a sixth of the 120-seat parliament and potentially emerging as kingmakers in efforts by Eisenkot to form a government

Why it matters **Economy**: India imports most of its crude oil, much of it from the Gulf; conflict raises oil prices, shipping and insurance costs, inflation and the current account defic; **Society**: About 9 million Indians live in the Gulf; their safety (evacuation operations such as Ajay/Kaveri) and remittances (India is the world's largest recipient) are

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

• **G7 Ministers meet on efforts to end Ukraine conflict, halt new Iran war** (The Hindu, International, 09 Nov 2026)
Ministers from the leading industrialised nations of Britain, Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan and the United States will be gathering with preoccupations strikingly similar to those of the last such meeting in March

Why it matters **International relations**: India's strategic autonomy: abstentions at the UN, call for dialogue and diplomacy, while keeping ties with Russia and the West.; **Economy**: Discounted Russian crude, fertiliser and defence spares; Western sanctions and secondary tariffs create payment and trade risks for India.

• **Tens of thousands march in Amsterdam, pressing Dutch government on Gaza, Israel** (The Hindu, International, 08 Nov 2026)

Organisers of the “Red Line” demonstration called for stricter trade sanctions, a halt to arms sales, and an official declaration that Israel’s actions in Gaza amount to genocide

Why it matters **Economy**: India imports most of its crude oil, much of it from the Gulf; conflict raises oil prices, shipping and insurance costs, inflation and the current account defic; **Society**: About 9 million Indians live in the Gulf; their safety (evacuation operations such as Ajay/Kaveri) and remittances (India is the world's largest recipient) are

• **Himalayas agenda left off COP31 formal list as major blocs withhold support: Nepal Foreign Minister** (The Hindu, International, 11 Nov 2026)

The dedicated agenda on the Himalayan ecosystem was excluded from the COP31 formal negotiations list due to lack of support from major geopolitical blocs.

Why it matters **International relations**: Underscores divergence between major geopolitical blocs and vulnerable mountain nations regarding climate negotiation priorities.; **Environment**: Risks delaying global adaptation finance and monitoring frameworks essential to avert Himalayan glacial retreat.

• **Is Trump’s ‘no-war, no-peace’ plan on Iran sustainable?** (The Hindu, International, 12 Nov 2026)

President’s decision to hold off on further strikes, he remains neck-deep in the war he launched alongside Israel’s Netanyahu on February 28 this year

Why it matters **Economy**: US is India's largest export market; tariffs, H-1B visa rules and trade-deal talks hit IT services, textiles, gems and pharma exports and the rupee.; **International relations**: Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership: defence deals, iCET/TRUST technology cooperation, Quad; India balances this with strategic autonomy (Russian oil, BR

• **Alice Huang, accused of spying on Nvidia chief, entered Taiwan eight times in 2024-25: Official** (The Hindu, International, 12 Nov 2026)

Taiwan, a dominant player in the global semiconductor industry, sits at the centre of strategic competition between the United States and China, which claims the self-ruled island as part of its territory

Why it matters **International relations**: India's Act East Policy and vision of a free, open, rules-based Indo-Pacific (UNCLOS 1982); Quad and ASEAN centrality.; **Economy**: A large share of India's trade passes through the Malacca Strait and South China Sea; disruption hits supply chains (semiconductors from Taiwan).

• **Netanyahu dismisses claims that Israel blocking supplies to Gaza** (The Hindu, International, 11 Nov 2026)

Benjamin Netanyahu said the Palestinian militant group Hamas is to blame because it continues to refuse to disarm, a condition of the deal announced by Donald Trump, and seizes humanitarian aid in order to use it for military purposes

Why it matters **Economy**: India imports most of its crude oil, much of it from the Gulf; conflict raises oil prices, shipping and insurance costs, inflation and the current account defic; **Society**: About 9 million Indians live in the Gulf; their safety (evacuation operations such as Ajay/Kaveri) and remittances (India is the world's largest recipient) are

• **Bharat Summit takes off in Hyderabad today; Rahul Gandhi to participate in valedictory** (The Hindu, National, 13 Nov 2026)

The gathering assumes significance as the first major international meeting of progressive leaders following electoral outcomes in Brazil, Hungary and Serbia, and comes soon after the United States mid-term elections

Why it matters **Economy**: US is India's largest export market; tariffs, H-1B visa rules and trade-deal talks hit IT services, textiles, gems and pharma exports and the rupee.; **International relations**: Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership: defence deals, iCET/TRUST technology cooperation, Quad; India balances this with strategic autonomy (Russian oil, BR

POLITY & CONSTITUTION

• **New Israeli parliament to take aim at Netanyahu as Eisenkot seeks government** (The Hindu, International, 10 Nov 2026)

President Isaac Herzog, ceremonially opening the session, called on all sides to work together and avoid a fresh election in a deeply polarised country weary from three years of war.

Why it matters **Economy**: India imports most of its crude oil, much of it from the Gulf; conflict raises oil prices, shipping and insurance costs, inflation and the current account defic; **Society**: About 9 million Indians live in the Gulf; their safety (evacuation operations such as Ajay/Kaveri) and remittances (India is the world's largest recipient) are

• **Indonesia's Vice President resigns as eligibility and academic credentials are questioned** (The Hindu, International, 12 Nov 2026)
The Constitutional Court and the Supreme Court ruled last month that the documents submitted by Gibran Rakabuming Raka, the 39-year-old son of former President Joko Widodo, regarding his overseas education didn't meet election requirements
Why it matters **Governance & polity**: Judicial review and the separation of powers; such rulings often clarify fundamental rights or federal relations and become Mains examples.; **Society**: Access to justice and pendency (over 5 crore cases) affect citizens' trust in institutions.

REPORTS & INDICES

• **INSA endorses G20 Science Academies' Joint Statement, reaffirming commitment to science-led solutions to global challenges** (PIB, Ministry of Science & Technology, 12 Nov 2026)
The Indian National Science Academy (INSA), an institution of the Department of Science and Technology (DST), actively participated in the S20 2026 process and endorsed the Joint S20 Statement, released by the science academies of the G20 countries, on Novembe
Why it matters **Economy**: US is India's largest export market; tariffs, H-1B visa rules and trade-deal talks hit IT services, textiles, gems and pharma exports and the rupee.; **International relations**: Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership: defence deals, iCET/TRUST technology cooperation, Quad; India balances this with strategic autonomy (Russian oil, BR

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

• **How AI is reshaping China's universities** (The Hindu, International, 10 Nov 2026)
AI disruption and a tightening job market are driving a sweeping change across China's universities; under the government's 'guideline on the reform of higher education institutions', universities will now be tasked with specific goals, pursuing either researc
Why it matters **Internal security**: Unsettled LAC (eastern Ladakh, Arunachal): border infrastructure, disengagement and buffer zones; China's dual-use villages (Xiaokang) and dams on the Brahmaput; **Economy**: Large trade deficit and dependence on Chinese inputs (APIs, electronics, solar, rare earths) drive PLI schemes, Press Note 3 (2020) FDI curbs and supply-chain d

• **India, France hold dialogues on economic security, space, technology** (The Hindu, National, 11 Nov 2026)
The two sides discuss supply chain vulnerabilities, critical technologies, cybersecurity and safeguarding strategic supplies, as part of the India-France Economic Security and Critical Technologies Dialogue
Why it matters **Internal security**: Cyber attacks on critical infrastructure and fraud like 'digital arrest' scams; CERT-In, NCIIPC and I4C are the response agencies.; **Governance & polity**: IT Act 2000, Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023, and the need for cyber hygiene and capacity in state police.

Prelims quick revision

• NFSA establishes legal entitlements for subsidized food grains, while TPDS distributes these grains to eligible…
• Export policy notifications for commodities are issued by the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) under the Ministry of Commerce and Industry.
• Lithium is designated as a critical and strategic mineral under the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2023.
• National Clean Air Programme (NCAP) targets reduction in PM2.5 and PM10 concentrations across non-attainment cities.
• The Himalayas are known as the 'Third Pole' due to holding the largest concentration of ice and snow outside the polar regions.

Static topics that came up this week

UNFCCC & Paris Agreement

• UNFCCC adopted at the 1992 Rio Earth Summit; the Conference of Parties (COP) meets yearly.
• Paris Agreement (COP21, 2015): keep warming well below 2°C, pursue 1.5°C; countries submit NDCs.
• India's targets include net zero by 2070.

APEC

• Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation, formed in 1989; 21 member economies around the Pacific Rim.
• India is not a member.

Blue Economy

• India's coastline is about 11,099 km (revised measurement) and its Exclusive Economic Zone about 2 million sq km.
• Schemes include PM Matsya Sampada Yojana and the Deep Ocean Mission.

Gaza Strip
• Narrow Palestinian territory on the Mediterranean coast, bordering Israel and Egypt (Rafah crossing).
• India's long-standing position supports a two-state solution.

UNESCO lists
• World Heritage under the 1972 Convention; Intangible Cultural Heritage under the 2003 Convention.
• UNESCO also runs the Man and the Biosphere (MAB) programme and Global Geoparks.

Air quality governance
• Commission for Air Quality Management in NCR (statutory since 2021) enforces the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP).
• National Clean Air Programme (NCAP, 2019) targets particulate reduction in non-attainment cities.

Taiwan Strait
• Separates Taiwan from mainland China and links the East and South China Seas.

G7
• US, UK, France, Germany, Italy, Japan and Canada, with the EU taking part; India is often invited as an outreach partner.

Quad
• India, the United States, Japan and Australia; focus on a free and open Indo-Pacific.

Critical Minerals Policy in India
• The Ministry of Mines identified 30 critical minerals essential for economic development and national security.
• Battery Waste Management Rules, 2022 mandate Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) targets for recovery and recycling of battery materials.

National Clean Air Programme (NCAP)
• Launched in 2019 by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC).
• Aims for a 40% reduction in PM concentrations by 2026 across non-attainment cities compared to 2017 levels.

G20
• 19 countries plus the EU and the African Union (AU joined in 2023 under India's presidency).

Qeshm Island (Iran)
• Largest island in the Persian Gulf, in Iran's Hormozgan province, across from the port of Bandar Abbas.
• Lies at the Strait of Hormuz; nearby islands: Hormuz, Larak, Kish; Abu Musa and the Greater/Lesser Tunbs are disputed between Iran and the UAE.
• Known for the Hara mangrove forests and a free trade zone.

Strait of Hormuz
• Connects the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea.
• Lies between Iran (north) and Oman's Musandam peninsula (south).
• Major chokepoint for crude oil and LNG exports from the Gulf, including a large part of India's energy imports.

Hindu Kush Himalaya (HKH) Region
• Spans across 8 countries including India, Nepal, Bhutan, and China.
• Sources 10 major river basins, supporting over 1.9 billion people downstream.